

Practice Paper 35 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — The teacup “almost broke my wrist”

1 mark for recognising that this is **hyperbole** / deliberate exaggeration.

1 mark for explaining that her muscles have **weakened** during six months in zero gravity, so an ordinary, light object now feels **unexpectedly heavy** to her.

Sample answer: The exaggeration shows that, after six months in space, her muscles have **atrophied** / **weakened**, so even a light cup feels almost impossibly heavy in Earth’s gravity.

Q2. [1] — “As though it belonged to someone else”

1 mark: She feels **detached** / **alienated** from her own body — she is so unfamiliar with how it responds to gravity that her own hand seems strange or foreign to her.

Q3. [2] — Gravity “had been a memory”

1 mark — On the station she had **no physical experience of gravity** at all; she lived without weight.

1 mark — She had only the **abstract idea** of gravity, something belonging to others on Earth and not to her own daily life — it had become almost theoretical.

Q4. [2] — Two details that show gravity affecting her body

1 mark each for any two of:

- Gravity is “in my elbows, in my eyelids” — even small body parts feel heavy.
- There is a “soft, unfamiliar pull at the base of my spine”.
- She tried “foolishly, to stand up too quickly” and was clearly affected.
- The cup itself feels as heavy “as a stone” (acceptable from Para 1 if cross-referenced; primary credit for Para 2 details).

Reject lifting “I had been warned about this” — this is not evidence of an effect.

Q5. [2] — “I had forgotten birds”

1 mark — The short, blunt sentence shows how **completely cut off** she was from ordinary Earth life on the station.

1 mark — It suggests her perspective has been **fundamentally altered**: even something as common and constant as birdsong has become unfamiliar, almost new.

Q6. [3] — Contrast between space and Earth sound

1 mark for identifying the **contrast** between the station’s continuous, mechanical hum and Earth’s sharp, varied, natural sounds.

1 mark each for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- On the station, sound was “a constant low hum — fans, pumps, the steady breath of the life-support system” — **mechanical, uniform, unchanging**.
- “The steady breath of the life-support system” **personifies** the machinery, suggesting how dominant and constant it was.
- On Earth, the birds are “impossibly loud” and argue “in clean, bright bursts” — sound is **sudden, natural, and unpredictable**.
- “A car door slammed three streets away and I flinched” — Earth sounds are **sharp** and **startling**, and her body has **not yet readjusted** to them.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**.

Q7. [2] — “Older and younger”

(a) [1] **Older:** She has new **fine lines around the eyes**, “the gift of half a year of unfiltered sunlight” through the station window — her face has **aged** physically.

(b) [1] **Younger:** Her **expression** is “startled, attentive, a little undone” — like a child seeing a kitchen for the first time. Her **wonder** at ordinary things makes her seem young again.

Q8. [2] — Why the husband was “sensible” to leave her alone

1 mark — He understood that there was a **private, quiet reunion** she needed to have **with the ordinary world itself** — with crockery, toast, the light on the floor.

1 mark — This reunion could **not be rushed** and was not something he could share with her — she needed **solitary time** to begin readjusting.

Q9. [2] — The tea contradiction

1 mark — The tea was **literally unremarkable**: warm water, leaves, a little milk — nothing special in itself.

1 mark — Yet, after six months of constant strangeness (“six months of remarkable”), **ordinariness itself had become precious / overwhelming**. She nearly wept out of **gratitude** for the everyday, which she had been deprived of for so long.

Q10. [1] — “Improbable”

1 mark: The word suggests that, from space, the Earth’s atmosphere looks **impossibly thin and fragile** — it is hard to believe that something so delicate could sustain all of life. (Also accept: a sense of **wonder**, that it should exist at all.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final paragraph

1 mark — Any **one** of: **peaceful, contented, grateful, settled, quietly joyful**. (Reject: **sad, anxious, bored** — these miss the calm acceptance.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Nodules compared to “potatoes”

1 mark — The comparison makes the nodules sound **small, familiar and unremarkable**, almost domestic.

1 mark — The **effect** is one of **surprise**: it sets up a striking contrast with the extraordinary value and age of the nodules revealed in the next sentences, drawing the reader in.

Q13. [2] — “Slow, patient handiwork of millions of years”

1 mark — The phrase emphasises how **unimaginably long** the nodules took to form (millimetres per million years).

1 mark — It also **personifies** nature as a careful, patient craftsman, suggesting the nodules are **precious** and **irreplaceable** on any human timescale.

Q14. [2] — Two reasons for mining the deep seabed

1 mark each for any two of:

- The world needs **several times more cobalt and nickel by 2040** to meet climate / clean-energy targets.
- Land-based supplies are **concentrated in a small number of countries** and are **politically fraught**.
- Land-based cobalt is **linked to documented abuses** in artisanal mines.
- The deep seabed is the **cleanest, fairest, and least exploited** source available.
- Seabed mining lets governments green one industry **without poisoning another**.

Q15. [2] — “The seabed is not a parking lot”

1 mark — A parking lot is an **empty, lifeless, low-value** surface that can be paved over without thought.

1 mark — The writer rejects the idea that the seabed is similarly empty or expendable: it is in fact **richly inhabited** and **full of life**, and so cannot simply be cleared.

Q16. [1] — “Years... centuries”

1 mark: The contrast shows that recovery takes **vastly longer than a human lifetime** — the damage is, in human terms, **effectively permanent / irreversible**.

Q17. [2] — “A slow grey snow”

1 mark — **Snow** is normally something **quiet, soft, and beautiful** — the image therefore makes the harm seem deceptive: harmless in appearance, yet smothering.

1 mark — The word **grey** suggests **waste / dirt**, and “slow” suggests **long, drawn-out suffocation** of creatures that evolved in extraordinarily clear water.

Q18. [2] — Why the ISA’s position is “awkward” (own words)

1 mark — The ISA is required to **regulate** (i.e. restrain) deep-sea mining.

1 mark — But it is **also** required to **promote** mining as a benefit to humanity. These two duties pull in **opposite directions**, creating an in-built **conflict of interest**.

Reject answers that lift “regulating” and “promoting” without explanation.

Q19. [1] — “Larger than the territory of India”

1 mark: The comparison shows the **enormous scale** of seabed already licensed for exploration, making vivid for the reader what would otherwise be an abstract figure. (Also accept: it **alarms** the reader / **underlines the urgency**.)

Q20. [2] — “No neutral path”

1 mark — Either choice has **serious consequences**: mining causes **irreversible damage** to a barely-known ecosystem.

1 mark — Not mining pushes the burden back onto **land-based supplies** with their own social and environmental costs, and **slows the energy transition** — there is no option that costs nothing.

Q21. [1] — Tone of final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **grave, urgent, sobering, warning, weighty**. (Reject: **cheerful, neutral**.)

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Arguments in favour of mining (Paragraph 2):

1. The world will need **several times more cobalt and nickel by 2040** to meet climate targets.
2. Land-based supplies are **concentrated in a few countries** and are **politically risky**.
3. Cobalt mined on land is **linked to human-rights abuses** in artisanal mines.
4. The seabed is presented as the **cleanest and fairest** source available — greening one industry without poisoning another.

Arguments against mining (Paragraphs 3–4):

5. The seabed is one of the **largest and least understood ecosystems** on Earth, home to many **undescribed species**.
6. Recovery from mining is measured in **centuries** — the damage is **effectively irreversible** on any human timescale.
7. Machinery creates a **plume of sediment** that drifts for tens of kilometres and **smothers** fragile deep-sea life.
8. **Waste water** released higher up threatens **mid-water fish**, including stocks the **global tuna industry depends on**; one **Nature** review called the costs “possibly catastrophic.”

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Supporters of deep-sea mining argue that the world urgently needs far more cobalt and nickel to meet climate goals, that land supplies are concentrated in a few unstable countries and tainted by human-rights abuses, and that the seabed is therefore the cleanest source available. Opponents reply

that the seabed hosts a vast, barely studied ecosystem whose recovery would take centuries, and that mining throws up sediment plumes which smother fragile species and threaten fish stocks above.

Length count: 78 words from “Supporters” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —